NOTRUMP OPENINGS

These 100 Deals are all about hands that are either opened 1NT or 2NT, or perhaps overcalled 1NT or 2NT. Some of them end up being played at a Notrump contract, but others are played with a trump suit.

The proficiency level for the Deals is Intermediate/Advanced, both in the Bidding and Declarer play.

ABOUT THE DEALS

With both hands visible and the opening lead noted you are asked to make a Plan for each Deal. You should think this through just as if you were at the table.

All of the Notrump Plans include a Winner Count and all Suit Plans include a Loser Count.

During the Bidding section you are in the South position. As a result of that some of the Deals would end up with your partner North as the Declarer.

ABOUT THE BIDDING

Normal 4-3-2-1 point count is used, with 1 length point added for any card more than 4 in any suit.
1NT Opening: 15-17 points
2NT Opening: 20-21 points
1NT Overcall: 15-18 points, at least 1, (preferably 2), stoppers in their suit
2NT Overcall over a Weak 2-bid: 15-18 points, at least 1, (preferably 2), stoppers

Stayman convention is used extensively.

Jacoby Transfers are used extensively.
In addition to the standard 2♦ transfer to ♥ and 2♥ transfer to ♠ we also use a 2♠ transfer to 3♣.

The **lebensohl** convention is used when opponents overcall your side's 1NT opening.
Since this is not a standard for many of you, a brief explanation/comment is given when it occurs.

You can go either go through the deals in order, or use the Navigation Bar at left.

Board: 1
Dealer: **North**

Contract: 4♠
Declarer: North
Lead: ♦Q

Board: 2
Dealer: **North**

Contract: 2♥
Declarer: East
Lead: ♠J

Board: 3
Dealer: **South**

Contract: 6NT
Declarer: South
Lead: ♥J

Board: 4
Dealer: **East**

Contract: 4♥
Declarer: West
Lead: ♠10

Board: 5
Dealer: **North**

Contract: 3NT
Declarer: North
Lead: ♦Q

Board: 6
Dealer: **East**

Contract: 3NT
Declarer: East
Lead: ♥6

Board 1
North Deals
None Vul

♠ K 10 9 3
♥ A K Q 5
♦ A 8
♣ A 8 6

♠ Q 6 2
♥ 8 7 3
♦ K 9 7 4 3
♣ K J



♠ 8 5
♥ 10 4 2
♦ Q J 10 5
♣ Q 10 9 4

♠ A J 7 4
♥ J 9 6
♦ 6 2
♣ 7 5 3 2

West	*North*	*East*	*South*
	2NT	Pass	3♣
Pass	3♥	Pass	3NT
Pass	4♠		
All Pass			

4♠ by North
Lead: ♦Q

Partner's 3♣ bid is Stayman; with 4 cards in both Majors you respond 3♥. Partner now bids 3NT.

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Partner would not use Stayman unless he held a 4-card Major suit himself. Since he didn't like your ♥s it follows that he must have 4 ♠s.

So you correct the 3NT contract to 4♠.

North plays 4♠. East leads the ♦Q.

If you had left it in 3NT you'd have 8 top tricks and a ♠ finesse for 9.

But you're in 4♠.

Loser List: ♠ = 1 : ♥ = 0 : ♦ = 1 : ♣ = 2 :: Total = 4

If you can guess the ♠Q your problems are over. But just in case you dislike those 50% guesses, try to find a better Plan.

Another possibility is that a defender holds either a singleton or doubleton ♠Q so you can pick up the suit by leading ♠ A K. This is smaller than a 50% chance.

But there is more to the odds than that. Suppose you try the second possibility and play off both the ♠A and ♠K but the ♠Q does **NOT** drop. You are still not dead! You just leave the ♠Q out there and start on ♥s. As long as the defender who holds the ♠Q has at least 3 ♥s he will be unable to ruff until after you have discarded dummy's ♦ loser.

The extra chance makes this Plan your best hope.

You could have made the contract easily by playing West for the ♠Q.

You could have gone down easily by playing East for the ♠Q.

Or you could have made it whoever held the ♠Q by using the "improved" plan.

Board 2
North Deals
None Vul

	♠ A Q 5 ♥ J 3 ♦ A J 10 3 ♣ Q J 10 8	
♠ K 8 7 3 ♥ 5 ♦ K Q 9 4 2 ♣ 9 4 3	N W E S	♠ 9 4 2 ♥ A Q 8 7 4 2 ♦ 6 ♣ K 7 5
	♠ J 10 6 ♥ K 10 9 6 ♦ 8 7 5 ♣ A 6 2	

West	*North*	*East*	*South*
	1NT	2♥	Dbl
All Pass			

2♥ by East
Lead: ♠J

East is to play 2♥ Doubled.

This is the only Deal like this out of the 100.

No Declarer Plan for you to make, no tricks to look for.

Just play through the deal as you think it might go and see how many tricks you can set East. Enjoy.

Sometimes the opponents make overcalls which disrupt the smooth flow of your side's bidding. You and your partner need to have ways of dealing with these disruptions. One possibility is the **lebensohl** convention which is used a few times in these 100 Deals. There are lots of other methods out there, and you may not care for lebensohl. One of the big reasons we use it is that it includes a penalty double - some other methods use the double for other reasons.

So, in lebensohl an immediate double of their overcall of partner's 1NT opener is for penalties. Just like this one - punish them if they dare try to disrupt your bidding!

The contract is 2♥ doubled, played by East.

To see all the hands

Board 3
South Deals
None Vul

♠ A 6
♥ 9 7 2
♦ K 10 8 3
♣ A K Q 5

♠ 9 5 3
♥ J 10 8 6
♦ Q 9 7 2
♣ 9 4



♠ 10 7 4 2
♥ A 5 4 3
♦ J 4
♣ 10 8 2

♠ K Q J 8
♥ K Q
♦ A 6 5
♣ J 7 6 3

West	*North*	*East*	*South*
			1NT
Pass	4NT	Pass	6NT
All Pass			

6NT by South
Lead: ♥J

Partner's 4NT bid is not Blackwood, it is the Quantitative 4NT. He is unsure whether to bid 6NT or not, so is inviting you to do so.

With 15 points you are supposed to pass. With 17 points you are supposed to bid 6NT. Wouldn't you know it, 16 points. Today you feel bold, so you say 6NT.

South plays 6NT. West leads the ♥J.

East plays the ♥A and returns the ♥3.

Winner List: ♠ = 4 : ♥ = 1 : ♦ = 2 : ♣ = 4 :: Total = 11

One trick is already lost and at first glance it looks like your only slim chance will be for the ♦ Q J to fall doubleton.

But a dummy has a very important card, the ♥9. You know from the opening lead that West holds the ♥10, so if he happens to hold the only guard in ♦s you will be able to squeeze him in the red suits.

You don't even have to do anything special. Play your 4 ♣ winners, then 3 ♠ winners.

Now play the ♠J and watch West's discard. If he throws the ♥10 dummy's ♥9 will become a winner. If he doesn't throw the ♥10 then you know dummy's ♥9 is worthless so discard it and hope the ♦s are good.

Squeeze plays can be complex to figure out and difficult to execute.

But not always. Sometimes they just happen, like this one. You were really hoping for the ♦Q and ♦J to fall and you fell into the squeeze instead.

Board 4
East Deals
Both Vul

	♠ 10 ♥ K 7 4 ♦ 9 8 4 2 ♣ 10 6 5 3 2	
♠ 8 5 2 ♥ Q 9 8 6 2 ♦ K Q 6 ♣ A 8		♠ Q 7 3 ♥ A 10 5 3 ♦ A J 7 ♣ K Q 9
	♠ A K J 9 6 4 ♥ J ♦ 10 5 3 ♣ J 7 4	

West	*North*	*East*	*South*
		1NT	2♠
3♥	Pass	4♥	
All Pass			

4♥ by West
Lead: ♠10

When partner opens 1NT, interference can easily gum up your smooth bidding sequences. Playing the lebensohl convention, your 3♥ bid shows a 5-card suit and is forcing to game.

It doesn't always work out so well, but here partner had an easy 4♥ bid.

West plays 4♥. North leads the ♠10.

Whatever you play, South takes the ♠ A K J and then plays a small ♣. North started with just one ♠.

Loser List: ♠ = 3 : ♥ = ? : ♦ = 0 : ♣ = 0 :: Total = ?

Don't let that Question Mark by the ♥ losers mislead you - if you are going to make this contract you cannot lose a ♥ trick at all! Is there any hope?

The odds aren't good, but you actually have **TWO** possibilities for success. If North holds the singleton ♥K, you can play a small ♥ to dummy's ♥A, dropping the ♥K, then finesse South out of his ♥J. Or, if South holds the singleton ♥J you can play your ♥Q, finessing North for the ♥K and at the same time smothering South's ♥J.

Which basket will you put your eggs into?

The answer is simple Bridge math! South started with 6 ♠s leaving him 7 cards outside the ♠ suit. North started with just 1 ♠, leaving him with 12 cards outside the ♠ suit. Obviously South is much more likely to have a singleton ♥ than North.

So you win the ♣A in your hand, play the ♥Q and let it ride if North does not cover.

Then you

Ahh, success.

But to tell the truth, the Bridge math wasn't really complete. Distribution-wise it was just fine, but there is also the question of strength.

The fact that South overcalled makes it more likely that he holds more high cards than North, and this skews the odds toward South holding the ♥K.

But think about it. If South does in fact hold the singleton ♥K, and if you cleverly drop it by playing dummy's ♥A it won't help you. You will then have to lose a trick to North's ♥J.

Board 5
North Deals
N-S Vul

	♠ K J 4 2 ♥ K 5 ♦ A K 6 ♣ K 9 7 4	
♠ 9 7 3 ♥ Q J 10 9 ♦ 9 4 2 ♣ Q 5 3	N W E S	♠ 10 8 5 ♥ A 6 2 ♦ Q J 10 7 5 ♣ J 6
	♠ A Q 6 ♥ 8 7 4 3 ♦ 8 3 ♣ A 10 8 2	

West	*North*	*East*	*South*
	1NT	Pass	2♣
Pass	2♠	Pass	2NT
Pass	3NT		
All Pass			

3NT by North
Lead: ♦Q

In response to partner's Stayman bid you show your 4-card ♠ suit. Partner now bids 2NT.

In response to partner's Stayman bid you show your 4-card ♠ suit. Partner now bids 2NT.

Partner had ♥s, not ♠s. His 2NT bid is invitational, 9-10 points, so with 17 points you say 3NT.

North plays 3NT. East leads the ♦Q.

Winner List: ♠ = 4 : ♥ = 0 : ♦ = 2 : ♣ = 2 :: Total = 8

You need one more winner. Although the ♥K is a possibility, there is a real danger of losing 4 tricks in the suit if East holds the ♥A.

A much better idea is to try to establish a ♣ trick, a suit where you hold 8 cards.

You must give up one ♣ trick in order to establish a winner there. It is important that you give up that ♣ trick to East. West is the Danger hand because if he wins a ♣ he might lead through your precarious ♥K. So win the first trick, enter dummy with a ♠ honor, and play a small ♣, finessing the ♣9 when West plays low.

East wins the ♣J, but you win the game. East cannot profitably play ♥s, so he will probably continue with another ♦. But since the ♣Q will now drop under the ♣ A K you have your ninth trick.

This ♣ holding shows an important principle. As long as the suit splits 3-2 you can establish the fourth card as a winner by ducking one trick.

The key is your ability to choose which defender you want to duck the trick into.

Board 6
East Deals
E-W Vul

	♠ Q J 9 7 ♥ 10 5 4 ♦ J 9 6 ♣ Q 9 6	
♠ K 8 6 2 ♥ Q 8 ♦ A 8 3 ♣ K 5 4 3	N W E S	♠ A 4 3 ♥ K 7 3 ♦ K Q 2 ♣ A 10 7 2
	♠ 10 5 ♥ A J 9 6 2 ♦ 10 7 5 4 ♣ J 8	

West	*North*	*East*	*South*
		1NT	Pass
2♣	Pass	2♦	Pass
3NT			
All Pass			

3NT by East
Lead: ♥6

With 12 points and a 4-card Major suit you automatically use Stayman; bid 2♣. Partner responds 2♦.

With 12 points and a 4-card Major suit you automatically use Stayman; bid 2♣. Partner responds 2♦.

You have plenty of points for game; with no 4-4 Major suit fit you bid 3NT.

The contract would be 3NT played by West.

East plays 3NT. South leads the ♥6.

First big decision. Which ♥ do you play from dummy?

Winner List: ♠ = 2 : ♥ = 1 : ♦ = 3 : ♣ = 2 :: Total = 8

The Rule of Eleven tells you there are 5 ♥s in West, North and East which are higher than the ♥6. You and dummy hold 4 of them so you can place North with just 1. The missing high cards are ♥ A J 10 9. Elementary, Watson; North must hold the ♥10 because from ♥ A J 10 6, ♥ A 10 9 6 or ♥ J 10 9 6 South would **NOT** have led the ♥6. So your first smart move is to play dummy's ♥Q, which holds the trick. What next?

You need to find one more winner and your best chance is the ♣ suit. You will need a 3-2 split in the suit, but you must establish the ♣ winner without letting North get the lead. North is the Danger Hand because he can play a ♥ throughyour ♥ K 7. Therefore it would be unwise to play ♣A, ♣K, then another ♣ because North is very likely to be the one with 3 ♣s.

Did you get it? Play a small ♣ toward your hand and put on the ♣10 if North plays low. You don't expect the ♣10 to win the trick, it is more of a duck than a finesse. South takes this with his ♣J but he can do you no harm. If he continues with ♥s your ♥K will be a second stopper. If he plays any other suit you will scamper home with your 9 tricks, which of course now include those 3 ♣s.

A duck into the safe hand allowed you to establish the ♣ winner you needed.

But what if North had figured out what you were going to try and played his ♣Q when you led from dummy?

He would have been very, very sorry. You would have had no choice but to win the trick, and when South's ♣J fell on the next trick you would have all 4 ♣ tricks!